

second, leaving traditionalists wondering whether FIFA had discovered new ways to monetise the game's natural rhythm.

Ticket prices placed many matches beyond the reach of ordinary supporters, even if the stands ultimately remained full. Travel between distant host cities was expensive and exhausting. The scale that made the tournament historic also made it cumbersome.

There were more serious concerns about refereeing and VAR.

Portugal's victory over Croatia became an almost continuous video review, with four goals disallowed in a single match. Egypt's dramatic defeat to Argentina produced accusations of inconsistency after a goal was ruled out, appeals for a late penalty involving Mohamed Salah were rejected and Argentina scored its winner soon afterwards. The Egyptian Football Association formally questioned the fairness and transparency of the officiating.

Argentina's quarterfinal against Switzerland brought further arguments over a red-card decision, while a tournament promoted as the most technologically advanced in history often demonstrated that more cameras did not necessarily produce greater agreement.

Nothing damaged that trust more than the case of Folarin Balogun. The United States striker was sent off following a VAR review, ordinarily carrying an automatic one-match suspension. But after President Donald Trump telephoned Infantino and publicly intervened, FIFA lifted the ban, allowing Balogun to face Belgium. FIFA argued that its disciplinary committee had independently determined that the offence did not merit suspension, but the optics were devastating.

Belgium coach Rudi Garcia called it a decision that would hurt both the World Cup and the United States. UEFA officials viewed it as a breach of established protocol, while the episode created the impression that football's laws could be renegotiated through access to political power.

It was an uncomfortable reminder that FIFA's closeness to the American



president had become one of the tournament's persistent subplots.

That relationship reached its awkward conclusion during the final presentation.

After Spain defeated Argentina 1-0 in New Jersey, Trump joined Infantino to present the medals and trophy. He was loudly booed by sections of the crowd but remained on the podium after Rodri had received the World Cup, standing prominently among the Spanish players as they started their celebrations. The image was difficult to ignore: a president accustomed to occupying every available camera angle standing beside a team whose greatest moment should have belonged entirely to them.

For all FIFA's excess, the political intrusion, the refereeing arguments and the relentless commercialisation, the tournament demonstrated something long suspected but never previously tested on such a scale.

The United States is ready for football.

Not merely for a version packaged as occasional entertainment, stripped of its culture and sold between other American sports. It was ready for the full, unruly game: the tribalism and tension, the tactical arguments, the national longing, the heartbreak of elimination and the songs that continued long after the players had left. The country did not suddenly abandon baseball, basketball or American football. Nor did everyone stop calling the game soccer. But for six weeks, the

Optics matter: Nothing dented FIFA's credibility more than the Folarin Balogun affair (right). REUTERS

distinction had hardly mattered.

Americans learned the names. They debated VAR. They complained about referees. They arranged work and travel around kick-off times. They discovered that a scoreless match could be gripping despite their own sports regularly producing double and triple-digit scores.

The World Cup came seeking a host. It left with a newfound audience.



FACTFILE

Number of teams

48

Number of players

1,039

Number of matches

104

Number of goals scored

308

Average goals per game

2.96

Total attendance

6,810,966